



Retired and Hurt

DELHI In hindsight, this was one announcement Sonia Gandhi would have regretted making. At a rally at Chandigarh in 2002, the UPA chairperson endorsed the demand for 'One Rank One Pension' (OROP). The Congress was also the only political party which called for OROP; that all ex-service-men draw the same pen-

sion regardless of the year they retire. This is not presently the case. The demand was also endorsed in the Congress's 2004 electoral manifesto. There are 20 lakh ex-servicemen in India.

The contentious Sixth Pay Commission is silent about OROP and has in fact widened the disparities between ex-servicemen. A

EMOTIVE: Ex-servicemen protest pension scales

soldier retiring on December 31, 2005, will draw Rs 4,667 per month throughout his life as pension. His compatriot retiring on January 1, 2006—the date from which the Sixth Pay commission comes into effect—will draw Rs 6,540 per month, a difference of 40 per cent. This has caused tremendous heart-burn among ex-servicemen. Hundreds, including retired major-generals and lieutenant-generals, were detained by the Delhi Police as they recently protested peacefully outside India Gate.

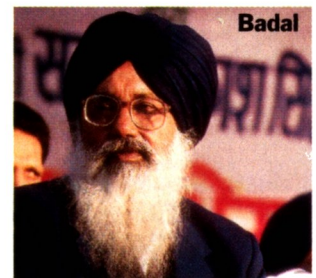
Over 55,000 personnel retire from the armed forces each year. Attempts to meet Sonia have proved fruitless. Madam is busy.

by Sandeep Unnithan

Rollback Row

CHANDIGARH The coming Lok Sabha polls are beginning to cast a shadow on Punjab. The ruling Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) has rescinded its order on officially observing October 31, the death anniversary of former prime minister Indira Gandhi, triggering a political row.

Following a routine circular from the Union Government to commemorate Indira's 23rd death anniversary as 'Sankalp Divas', the state had instructed all districts to organise speeches, debates



Temple Trouble

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM It is the richest and most popular shrine in the state, but the Ayyappa Temple at Sabarimala Hills is never free from controversies. It is now embroiled over the appointment of the 'melsanthi' (head priest) for the annual festival beginning next month.

For the first time the Kerala High Court has stayed the appointment of the priest this year by the state-appointed Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) which administers the state's 2,000-odd temples. The court was acting on complaints regarding



CONTROVERSIAL APPOINTMENT: The Ayyappa Temple

the selection of the priest. However, it allowed the TDB to select the melsanthi by the usual draw of lots from the qualified candidates' list. The court has barred any appointments until it receives an inquiry report into the antecedents of the candidates.

The post of melsanthi is coveted: he can earn up to Rs 1 crore from the dakshina paid to him by the three crore devotees during the festival. The temple itself receives about Rs 100 crore in from devotees.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

and patriotic songs on the occasion. But the instructions raised the hackles of Akali leaders and radical Sikh bodies who slammed the SAD-BJP Government for eulogising Indira who had ordered Operation Bluestar in 1984.

Realising that it could damage its Panthic credentials, Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal promptly withdrew the order. "We have nothing to do with Sankalp Divas," was Badal's cryptic response. "The SAD leadership has no qualms in seeking favours from the UPA Government led by Sonia Gandhi but is fighting shy of observing Sankalp Divas," said Leader of the Opposition Rajinder Kaur Bhattal.

by Ramesh Vinayak